Author’s Note

Everyone has a migration story. I can vividly remember the day I had first landed in a new place for schooling, for higher studies, for work, and even for love. Divya, my wife, and I have now lived in five different cities across three continents, and when we look back at old photographs, we recollect how we pulled it off through beautiful landscapes, unending winters, strange furniture designs and restrictive visa laws. Memory, nostalgia and selective amnesia are powerful ingredients used to pepper personal and family migration narratives. These migration stories collectively form a system of internal and international migrations, of voluntary and involuntary migrations and many other such typologies. This book is about one regional migration system—India—which has witnessed some of the largest voluntary and involuntary mass migrations in history. It is also the first book on the history of both internal and international migration and voluntary and involuntary migration related to India.

The book describes the origins of the incredible human diversity found within India and covers the migrations of artisans, merchants, slaves, students, warriors, workers, women, and many others. It reveals the persistence of labour migration since the late 19th century, and provides a new perspective on the migration of business communities both within and outside India. It shows how 25 million people who traced their roots to India in the past three centuries were dispersed across the world from Japan to Jamaica, and why internal diasporas matter as much as international diasporas. It documents the mass migrations caused by multiple partitions, refugee crises and other displacements in Indian history and their disproportionate impact on particular communities. And finally, it provides a perspective on migration and development, in history and in 21st century India.